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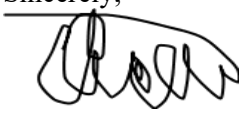
Dear DTA Committee Member,

On behalf of the English Department, I am very pleased to nominate Katarina Yuan for the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Katarina students become more confident, and more self-aware learners because she subscribes to and has studied deeply the key learning concepts of growth mindset and metacognition. To encourage students to understand better their own writing process, Katarina uses a portfolio system of writing assessment. Perhaps I should mention a. third key teaching method Katarina employs to benefit her students: transparency. She explains carefully on her syllabus (and throughout the quarter) *why* she asks students to compose their work in a portfolio: "We structure the writing assignments this way to emphasize the importance of feedback and revision–90% of writing is rewriting. This system also encourages the growth mindset: we are all here to improve as writers, regardless of our starting point. The final portfolio gives you the opportunity to revisit earlier writing with the skills you have accumulated by the end of the quarter. While we would ideally revise all 3 papers, the last paper is due at the end of the quarter to ensure adequate time between papers." I cannot quote from the feedback Katarina provides to her students, but that, too, encourages students to think of writing as a skill they can improve rather than a natural talent that one is born with or not. Katarina's feedback is also notable for using the suggestive mode: Katarina's students learn about strategies they can use to improve their writing. The final portfolio contains a self-statement where students describe their growth, what writing strategies they learned and how that made their work more effective.

Katarina employs another high-impact practice in cultivating a collaborative learning community where students are not just encouraged to respond to each other during discussion but prompted to use their peers' ideas in their essays, as one of her students explains, "Always encouraging and facilitating discussion about assigned material during lecture really created a space for collaboration and collective learning. The times where I didn't understand the core themes of the assigned readings were clarified by having the opportunity to hear my classmates' interpretations and analysis. I was able to incorporate some of the interpretation of my classmates with my own twist or take in my essays which has helped me grow as open–minded writer overall." Katarina understands that learning happens through self-reflection combined with collaboration.

Katarina's students are more capable and self-sufficient learners because she has taken the time on her own to study the key concepts of growth mindset and metacognition. Katarina's extra effort on behalf of her students deserves recognition by way of the Distinguished Teaching Award.

Sincerely,



Christopher M. Mott
TA Coordinator

Katarina Yuan
Distinguished TA Award

Nominee Self-Statement

I am honored to receive the English department's nomination for the Distinguished TA Award. My independent teaching in Writing II courses provides a foundation for critical reading and writing not just for English majors, but across all disciplines at UCLA. I most commonly teach English 4W: a course in which the students hone the fundamentals of argumentative writing and literary analysis. These 4W courses must provide breadth of form, culture, and time period, while simultaneously providing thematic cohesion that allows our students to develop nuanced interpretive questions about our society. I have taught 4W five times with three different syllabi, each time creating a new theme to provide opportunities for my students to think interdisciplinarily about our literature. In my first 4W, my students considered how writers use cannibalism as a metaphor for capitalist exploitation, sexual domination, and colonial power. To help my students challenge how the literary canon creates national identity, my next 4W focused on diasporic writers who explore colonialism and immigration through alien invasion narratives. In my latest 4W, the students analyze how Asian American writers use science fiction and fantasy to both create and challenge the category of "Asian America." Each time I make a new syllabus, I ensure my texts not only provide ample literary insights, but also provide opportunities to debate the politics, history, and economics of our time. To help my students connect these themes to their STEM courses, I pull from my own background as an English and Biology double major. We discuss how literary and data analysis go hand-in-hand, comparing our thesis statements to lines of best fit in a scatterplot. I coach my students to enhance their literary interpretations with their lab research–such as through interpreting a science fiction

novel's queer allegories through evolutionary theory. My classes not only prepare students for the English major, but for all their future writing and analytical endeavors.

Our students' growth does not end when the class ends, and therefore I commit to mentoring my students to graduation and beyond. Mentorship begins during the quarter as I help my students revise their papers; each feedback opportunity allows me to learn their scholarly and personal interests and to advise their growth as writers and critics. After the quarter ends, I keep in close contact with former students and mentor them as they strive to connect their academics to their future career. In our meetings, we talk extensively about how they may mesh their livelihoods with their passions–discussing what inspires them, what familial and economic pressures they face, and how they wish to grow in the future. I encourage these students not to lean on me alone, but to cultivate larger support networks of their peers, family, and professors that will support their continual growth. Throughout my teaching, I instill in my students the belief that mentor and peer relationships are key not just for academic success, but also for personal fulfillment.

Such commitments to interdisciplinarity and mentorship are only possible because I am constantly in conversation with the thriving teaching community here at UCLA. By the end of the year, I will have completed the Writing Pedagogy Certificate with a focus on writing in the disciplines. Next quarter, I will be teaching a Writing II seminar in the 60s cluster. As I pursue my own pedagogical improvement, I endeavor to contribute to the rich tradition of peer mentoring in the English department. As other graduate students develop their 4Ws and become independent teachers, I help them develop their syllabi, assignments, and lesson plans. I open my door to these graduate students to sit in on my 4Ws to experience my in-class activities firsthand. I'm delighted that some of my activities (such as the carousel for poetry analysis, which I

explicate in my teaching artifacts) have become a staple of the English department's pedagogical tools and have even been incorporated into our 495 series.

I began my writing journey as a creative writer who wanted to pursue science communication, but then I became entranced by literary analysis. I only could make the pivot to my ideal career because of the mentors who helped me see the connections between my passions. In my commitments to my students and to my fellow teachers here at UCLA, I hope to continue the work of those who came before me.

Katarina Yuan
Distinguished TA Award

Statement of Teaching

Our students often come into our classrooms with a single goal: to get an A. They have been mis-taught that their purpose is to be evaluated, leading to undue anxiety that makes them shy away from the very areas of ignorance and discomfort where learning happens. This mindset discourages growth in favor of shortcuts masquerading as learning–shortcuts that AI increasingly provides. I help my students unlearn this mindset through encouraging them to find joy in the messy process, not value in the neat end product.

To encourage joy in the learning process, we work to bridge the false divides between academic rigour and personal passion. In my syllabi, I pair high and low culture, literary and genre fiction, to reveal how our academic interests and self-indulgent pastimes are always already in conversation with each other. We read the works of traditional literary figures like Jonathan Swift or Maxine Hong Kingston alongside Mila Zuo's indie horror short films and Darcie Little Badger's YA novels to break down the false divide of high and low culture–a divide that so often insists that marginalized storytellers may only be literary if they focus on trauma and oppression at the expense of joy and imagination. Our texts reveal how the escapist and fantastic allow us to learn about the historical and even traumatic. In Trung Le Nguyen's *The Magic Fish*, whimsical yet horrific fairytales allow a Vietnamese American family to process how grief, queer shame, and refugee traumas exist alongside the childish joys of puppy love and school dances. We learn to read for Orientalism through *Dungeons and Dragons* manuals to invite our academic readings into our hobbies and our hobbies into our academics. I encourage my students to bring their family histories and their passion projects into class, because who they

are and what they love will always shape their literary arguments for the better. Rather than chasing the false notion of objective truth, we celebrate how literary interpretation is always inherently personal and creative. In this way, we form a deep connection with our texts and with the learning process–a learning process that began before we entered the classroom and that will continue after we leave, because it is part of who we are.

To maintain this passion for the process, we must unlearn the ways we value grades over our own growth. In my ENGL 4W classes (our introduction to literary analysis), I design our assignments around revision. I return each literary analysis paper to them with extensive feedback and a temporary grade. At the end of the quarter, my students resubmit revised versions of their papers in a final portfolio. The grades for these revised drafts completely replace the temporary grades. I do this to de-emphasize the grades and re-emphasize the importance of feedback and growth. The goal of a writing class is not merely to improve our writing, but also to get a better sense of our writing–where we struggle, where we thrive, and what makes us unique–so that we can continue to grow as writers. Re-emphasizing feedback models the real-world writing process while encouraging students to cultivate their own editorial eye and distinctive writerly voice. The safety net of revision allows many students to take creative risks with their papers–opening with jokes, closing with personal anecdotes, and structuring arguments around puns and extended metaphors. Rather than stifle them into more conventional writing, my feedback guides them to hone these distinctive, often quirky voices into sharp analytical and argumentative tools. Likewise, revision frees students to bite off more than they can chew in an argument–giving them an opportunity to grow to match these ambitious takes. Through revision, the students reframe discomfort and struggle not as personal failures in their writing, but as opportunities for growth, creativity, and ingenuity.

Our growth is not solely our own responsibility–we work communally to encourage each other's curiosity. As the students revise their papers, they work in pairs to reverse outline each other's writing and re-outline the papers for smoother flow of thought. This paired outlining activity emphasizes the role of the audience in guiding our augment, allowing students to see how writing is always an opportunity for communication and connection. We also communally create arguments in class using "carousel" activities. In a carousel, the class is divided into groups, with each group close reading a particular poem. After a set amount of time, the students switch poems and must pick up where the other group's analysis left off. We repeat this process until every student has analyzed every poem. In the final round, the students return to their original poem and write thesis statements, which the class then workshops together. This activity breaks down the steps of brainstorming an argument to demystify the writing process. Simultaneously, it asks the students to work on each other's arguments to see how their individual interpretations build off of the insights and curiosities of their peers. This activity teaches them that writing is not a solitary endeavor, but always a response to the interests of the writers who came before us. As the students work on each other's arguments, they become deeply invested in literary analysis as a process of connection, care, and conversation rather than perfection.

When I encounter former students on campus, they often bring up two things in the same breath: the texts they still think about and the classmates they still write with. While I am always honored that our class materials follow them so many months later, I am even more humbled by their ongoing commitments to writing with each other. These students remind me that our literary work is not just a passion project, but an ongoing process of care–our care for the texts, for each other, and for ourselves.

Katarina Yuan's Teaching Artifacts

Artifact 1: The Carousel Activity

Explanation:

In a carousel, students are divided into small groups. Each group is given a poem to analyze and annotate, with a prompt to guide their analysis. After a set amount of time (roughly 10 minutes), the students switch to a new poem and must build off their classmates' annotations to continue their analysis. The first round's prompt mimics the students' weekly discussion posts, asking students to provide a surface reading and pose questions that could lead to literary analysis. The second and third rounds prompt the students to begin the close reading process (i.e., the process of annotating and dissecting a literary piece to understand how it builds meaning) for literary analysis. Round four connects these analytical skills to our argumentative skills through forming a thesis statement. All subsequent rounds reinforce thesis statement structure and the importance of revision.

The carousel activity utilizes group work and the constant switching of poems to help the students see how literary analysis is always done in conversation with other readers. Switching mid-analysis also provides a writing challenge–the students can only communicate to the next group via their annotations, challenging them to make these annotations both thorough and clear. The goal of the carousel is to break down the steps of brainstorming a literary argument in digestible chunks–clarifying the early (often confusing) stages of the writing process.

Below are the carousel instructions (normally displayed in a series of powerpoint slides), 2 sample annotated poems, and a sample thesis statement revision.

Carousel Instructions:

Round 1: Summarize the poem. What themes do you notice? What interpretive questions do you have?

Round 2: What literary devices does the poet use?

- Metaphorical language
- Diction, mood, and tone
- Speaker or persona

Round 3: What are the formal elements of the poem?

- Line breaks
- End-stopped vs. enjambed lines
- Meter
- Rhyme
- Soundplay: assonance, consonance, alliteration

Round 4: Choose an interpretive question to answer. Write a thesis statement answering this question using the evidence you've observed.

- What argument do you make?
- How do you prove it?
- Why do we care?

Round 5: Share your thesis statement with the class and receive instructor feedback.

Round 6: Revise your thesis statement.

free verse – meter & rhyme different across lines

4 lines/stanza

assonance, consonance, and alliteration

consonance – "m"/"n" and alliteration

create sense of flow even though it's free verse

Zero Gravity

Eric Gamalinda (1999)

-surreal language -> patterns
-hope for the future

oxymoron

The dry basin of the moon must have held enjambed
the bones of a race, radiant minerals
or something devoid of genesis, angel-heavy
idea-pure. All summer we had waited for it

-> religious connection

end-stopped lines

our faces off-blue in front of the TV screen
Nothing could be more ordinary—two figures
digging dirt in outer space—while mother repeated
Neil Armstrong's words, like a prayer

enjambed

assonance

scientific marvel or divine influence?

(... they rise to heaven or smth)

electronically conveyed. The dunes were lit
like ancient silk, like clandestine pearl.
In the constant lunar night this luminescence
was all we hoped for. A creature unto itself,

simile

end-stopped

assonance of "ell" sound

- a creature...
- a flood...

↳ non-human
↳ divine

it poured into the room like a gradual flood
of lightning, touching every object with the cool burn
of something not quite on fire. If we stepped out
Manila would be blank ether, way station,

"visual rhyme"

simile

oxymoron

enjambed

end-stopped

frozen, insignificant

a breathless abeyance. It didn't matter
at that moment, where our lives would lead:
father would disown one brother,
one sister was going to die. Not yet unhappy

relationship with the US

we were ready to walk on the moon. Reckless
in our need for the possible, we knew
there was no turning back, our bags already packed
the future a religion we could believe in.

enjambed

nationalism

immigration aspect?

↳ fairn

speaker is VERY generic
↳ what effect does that have?
↳ universally applicable

what's his relationship to America?

looking back on his life
wrote about the moon landing decades later

moon landing was a big deal

religious imagery with immigration or hope for the future

how: contrast between spiritual and surreal imagery
why: moon landing change perception on America and how we accomplished the "impossible"
what: confliction between past and present emotions regarding the moon landing

meters: trochaic tri~~tetra~~meter
trochaic tetrameter
Iambic trimeter
trochaic tetrameter
trochaic tetrameter

symbol of femininity ↓ could mere be a romantic name?

"Tanka III" (excerpted from "Tanka")

Sadakichi Hartmann (1916)

. rhymes at end
. consonance with m sounds (moon, somn, mirror)

end-stopped

Iambic trimeter

6 Moon, somnolent, white,
7 Mirrored in a waveless sea,
6 What fickle mood of night
7 Urged thee from heaven to flee
7 And live in the dawnlit sea?

S sounds = hushed sounds like the "waveless sea"

m & w = harmonious sounds

only enjambed lines in the poem

end-stopped

dawn = transition from night to day + moon ficking from heaven + "fickle" = evanescence of beauty / nature

Q: why make transition from trochaic to iambic more promptly with Tanka I?

Q: what goes ignored in nature by us?

Q: what does the poem say about immigration?

- Somber tone
  - waveless sea → still
  - night

uncertainty and confusion (mood)

Q: why choose outside narrorator

waveless sea → dawnlit sea
new life

-personification of the moon moving

-heaven being somewhere you don't live
  -immigrating to "live"

In Tanka III, Sadakichi Hartmann reflects on the struggles of immigration

In Tanka III, Sadakichi Hartmann uses

Example Carousel Thesis Statement Revision

First Thesis Statement:
Poem: “Zero Gravity” by Eric Gamalinda
What are we arguing?: Difference between past perspective and current perspective
How are we arguing it?: Contrast between religious and surreal imagery
Why do we care?: America’s neocolonization of the Philippines

Feedback: Wonderful specificity in the “why” and “how” of this thesis statement! To make your “what” more specific and arguable, create a relationship between it and your “why.” For example: Is the speaker disillusioned because of American neocolonialism? Are they nostalgic for the moon landing and their past belief in American exceptionalism?

Revised Thesis Statement: In “Zero Gravity,” Gamalinda juxtaposes religious and surreal imagery to illustrate the dissonance between his naive childhood reverence of the United States and his current jaded perspective as an immigrant from a country caught up in America’s neocolonial foreign policy.

Artifact 2: Syllabus Excerpt (Reading and Assignment Schedule)

Explanation:

Below is a sample reading and assignment schedule for English 4W. All of the readings fit a given theme (in this case, Asian American sci-fi and fantasy) while providing diversity across that theme (in this case, ensuring the authors span the major regions of Asia and the United States). The readings must also introduce the students to as many different forms as possible. In this case, we focus on poetry, short story, short film, the novel, the graphic novel, film, and games. (Notably, only poetry, short fiction, the novel, and film/theater are required forms for 4W.) To lower the financial burden on the students, all readings marked with an asterisk are accessible via our class Google Drive. To ensure writing skills remain at the center of the course, each week focuses on one aspect of writing (named in that week’s header).

This class has 3 analytical papers staggered throughout the quarter, which students ultimately compile into a final portfolio at the end of the quarter. For the first two papers, the students have the opportunity to revise their paper based on my feedback. I will re-grade these revised papers at the end of the quarter, with the revision grade completely replacing the original grade. These revisions mimic the importance of feedback and rewriting to the real-world writing process. Simultaneously, these revisions encourage the growth mindset by allowing students to revisit earlier work with their new skills. In all, the final portfolio assignment decreases the pressure of grades to instead emphasize the learning process.

Week 1: Close Reading

Sept. 29: Introduction

In-class: *SpaceMosque*, Saks Afridi

Oct. 1: Asian / American Poetry

"Tanka I," Sadakichi Hartmann*
"Telemachus," Ocean Vuong* [tw: death]
"If They Should Come for Us," Fatimah Asghar

Week 2: Thesis Statements

Oct. 6: Asian / American Poetry: Imagining Space

"Tanka III," Sadakichi Hartmann*
"Zero Gravity," Eric Gamalinda*
"Pluto Shits on the Universe," Fatimah Asghar*
"If They Should Come for Us," Fatimah Asghar*

Oct. 8: Soft Science

Soft Science, Franny Choi [tw: grief/death, discussion of rape culture]

Week 3: Analyzing Form and Voice

Oct. 13: Science Fiction and the Poetry of Cognitive Estrangement

"A Refuge for Jae-in Doe: Fugues in the Key of English Major," Seo-Young Chu* [tw: graphic depictions of sexual assault, self-harm, suicidal ideation]
Do Metaphors Dream of Literal Sleep? excerpt from "Introduction," p. 1-31, Seo-Young Chu*

Oct. 15: Imagining the Orient

"Carnal Orient," Mila Zuo (horror short film) [tw: gore, themes of sexual assault]
Orientalism excerpt, Edward Said*

Week 4: Short fiction and Analyzing Across Form

Oct. 20: Palestinian diasporas, Palestinian futurisms

Palestine+100, "Vengeance," Tasnim Abutabikh*
"A Space Exodus," Larissa Sansour, 2008
The Question of Palestine, "Palestine and the Palestinians," p.3-15, Edward Said*

Oct. 22: Indigenous Imaginaries and Graphic Narrative: Rae Kuruhara (English PhD candidate, they/them)

"Indigenous Wonderworks and the Settler-Colonial Imaginary," Daniel Heath Justice*

Paper #1 due Wednesday, October 22nd, at midnight

Week 5: The Novel and Essay Organization

Oct. 27: Ancestor Worship

Salt Fish Girl, Larissa Lai, opening- end of "The Memory Disease" [tw: medical abuse]

Oct. 29: Colonialism, Capital, and Queer Time

Salt Fish Girl,"The Island of Mist"- "A Song for Clara Cruise" [tw: medical abuse]

Week 6: The Novel (cont.)

Nov. 3: Salt Fish Girl

Salt Fish Girl, "The New Kublai Khan"-end.

Nov. 5: Graphic Novels and Fairytales

The Magic Fish, Trung Le Nguyen, p. 1-125 ("the space between two shores is an ocean…")

Week 7: Taking Feedback

Nov. 10: Queerly Ever After

The Magic Fish, p. 126-end.

Nov. 12: Model Minority Multiverse

Everything Everywhere All at Once, directed by Daniel Scheinert & Daniel Kwan

Week 8: Workshopping

Nov. 17: Laundry and Taxes

Everything Everywhere All at Once

Nov 19: Writing Workshop

No reading

Paper 2 due Friday, Nov. 21, at midnight

Week 9: New Media and Games

Nov. 24: Dungeons & Dragons Modules: Playing with Empire

Advanced Dungeons and Dragons: Oriental Adventures, David "Zeb" Cook*:

"Preface" by Gary Gygax (p. 3)

"Introduction" by David "Zeb" Cook" (p. 4)

Oriental Adventures: Swords of the Daimyo, David "Zeb" Cook*:
Adventure Book: "Adventures 1-3" (p. 3-15; p. 4-17 of pdf)
Province Book: "Introduction" (p. 1-5; p. 36-39 of pdf)
Al-Qadim: Arabian Adventures, Jeff Grub (and Andria Hayday)*
"Introduction" (p. 8-9)
"The Land" and "The People" (p. 10)
Al-Qadim: Golden Voyages, Jeff Grub*
"The Great and Dread God" (p. 8-16; p. 41-9 of pdf)

Nov. 26: NO CLASS, Paper 3 work day

THANKSGIVING BREAK: November 27-28

Week 10: Wrap-up

Dec. 1: Desi Dungeons & Dragons
DesiQuest, "Big Uncle Energy"
Made in Asia/America, "Introduction," Chris Patterson and Tara Fickle*

Dec. 3: Final Celebration
No reading; in-class workshopping

Final portfolio due Friday, December 12th, at midnight

Artifact 3: Student Feedback (compiled from SET comments)

Katarina is a wonderful teacher. It was clear from the get go that she really wanted her students to thrive and improve their writing skills in this class. She was always patient and encouraging, always embracing students' analyses and ideas about our material. All the readings were very applicable to the course theme and material, and the workload was never overwhelming. I also really like the way she spaced out the three papers and the portfolio, allowing us to revise our papers for a new grade at the end of the quarter. I think this really facilitates student learning because the most important step of writing is revision, which she also always stressed to us. She is also very thoughtful and understanding, always offering extensions on assignments. Lastly, I think the way that she roots class material in salient themes like colonialism, race, gender, sexuality, etc., is really important for undergraduate education and also really speaks to her extensive knowledge. Thank you Katarina!

Katarina has been one of my favorite lecturers/instructors in my four years at this institution. She made concepts in English and writing that I had struggled with before more fun, accessible, and understandable. She was always very kind and willing to listen to student feedback. Her class times were a comfortable place where I could ask questions regardless of whether I thought they were dumb. She always helped me find insightful answers without making me feel like I knew nothing. The course tempo and assignments were manageable and exciting. I enjoyed being in class every week and doing the readings and assignments because I knew I could go to Katarina if I didn't understand something, whether in class or during office hours. I could take advantage of her office hours and approach without the intimidation I usually feel from instructors. My knowledge and practice with writing have been highly positive in this course, and I encourage anyone to take this class with Katarina. There are so many positive things to say that I am left with the need to say more, but Katarina is extremely hardworking, engaged, and an excellent teacher. Anyone would be lucky to learn from her.

Katarina is an awesome instructor! What I really appreciate about her is her passion and excitement around literature because it made everyone more engaged with the material. She provides detailed, specific feedback on papers, which is also great, unlike other professors who might give more generic feedback. I like how she fostered group discussions and peer workshops, too, because it made us more comfortable with each other. She was always very encouraging and supportive. I have nothing bad to say about her or this course-- she is excellent, and the course was really fun.

Katarina is fantastic at guiding conversations during class to help everyone dissect the content and understand the analysis while also prompting us as a class to grow in our skills. She is also great at reassuring us and building our confidence by continuously pointing out where we have improved over time as a class. Doing so not only makes us proud of our progress, but encourages us to explore our skills even further in the future. In addition, the readings she has chosen for the class were always very manageable to read, and also highly interesting and engaging. I highly appreciated how inclusive Katarina was in choosing the material in not only form (poem, short story, short film, novel, film), but also in the background of authors (race,

sexuality, immigration status, etc.). Additionally, her understanding and leniency is highly appreciated and I am extremely thankful for how understanding she was of our various circumstances that would require an extension. I have never felt judged or inferior for the analysis I offer in the class, nor have I seen Katarina be that way towards any other students. She is relentlessly kind and empathetic and incredibly encouraging in a manner that is clearly genuine and passionate like no other. I would highly recommend for her to teach any English course as she has been one of the most empathetic and encouraging professors I have had while making the course highly interesting and engaging. I have nothing but high praise for Katarina and the way she has organized the course.

Yuan was incredibly kind always and taught with a high level of mastery of the subject with a kindness that encouraged us students to speak up in an English analysis atmosphere. I truly appreciated that it was clear that she had deeply thought into every topic and made extraordinary pulls to connect the material and make metaphors. Her passion came through clearly always and she never had an off day.

Katarina was such a caring and informed instructor. It is obvious that she cares about her students and fosters a space in which they feel encouraged to experiment with writing and various forms of analytical literature. Not only that, she normalizes mistakes and views them as learning opportunities and achievements, allowing room for authentic correction and growth. I always felt welcomed in the class and thoroughly enjoyed every discussion that we had, facilitated by Katarina's guidance and mastery of close reading. She offered nuanced and unique perspectives and made my experience of English 4W so nurturing and enjoyable. I am walking away from this class with greatly improved writing and analytical skills and will value the lessons I learned from Katarina for the rest of my writing and academic career.

Instructor Yuan is an enthusiastic learner alongside her students . Always encouraging and facilitating discussion about assigned material during lecture really created a space for collaboration and collective learning. The times where I didn't understand the core themes of the assigned readings were clarified by having the opportunity to hear my classmates interpretations and analysis. I was able to incorporate some of the interpretation of my classmates with my own twist or take in my essays which has helped me grow as open–minded writer overall.

I really liked that this class was discussion–based. My expectations when entering the class were that I was just gonna hear presentations about books or English materials. However, my expectations were defied. I liked that I was forced to talk with others and have meaningful discussions that allowed me to connect with whatever was discussed that day. I felt like I was in a supportive environment, which allowed me to feel comfortable about sharing my actual thoughts. I also found the materials for this class to be incredibly interesting. I can definitely see myself resisting texts such as "The Magic Fish" in the future. Even the materials that weren't readings were fun to go over including the movie "Everything, Everywhere, All at Once" and "Dungeons and Dragons."

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Despite the two-hour class blocks, Katarina's discussions were always engaging. While everyone in the class knew Katarina was the resident Asian American Science Fiction expert, she facilitated and fueled our discussions, rather than dominating them. My classmates and I always had the chance to form our own ideas–chalkboard rotations, shared google slides, pen-and-paper activities–before Katarina offered constructive feedback. This was inspiring, because as a yapper myself, Katarina taught me how to pull other people comfortably into the conversation and truly build on each other's ideas, rather than just patiently waiting for other people to start talking. Katarina also inspired me to approach more forms of media with a critical eye. Not only can I approach books and poems with scholarly analysis, but my everyday podcasts and Dungeons and Dragons campaign influence how my worldview is shaped. Katarina's lessons were helpful for my writing skills, but more importantly, a timely demonstration on how to really get people discussing the social consequences and opportunities that media can provide.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Katarina gave her students every single opportunity for improvement, putting in insane amounts of hours and offering the flexibility that undergraduate students need to thrive. As someone who took this class as a GE, I often had to prioritize my other coursework over 4W. However, Katarina offered every single student a no-questions-asked extension, meeting students where they were at and offering them the flexibility to write to the best of their abilities. What's more, Katarina implemented essay grading policies that proved her prioritization of learning. Besides leaving thorough comments to show exactly where students earned or lost points, Katarina used something she called "grade normalization" – once the entire classes' papers were graded, she would read back over every single essay to make sure she graded consistently. Then, after our initial grade, Katarina permitted us to revise our essays for our final portfolio, then completely re-graded our essays post-revisions. Katarina cut no corners when providing her students opportunity for growth–while it required her to read every single students' essays at least fourfold, Katarina gave me both the concise feedback and submission flexibility to fuel my growth as a writer.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH
149 KAPLAN HALL
BOX 951530
LOS ANGELES, CA 90095-1530

11 February 2026

Dear Committee Members,

I write to strongly support Katarina Yuan as a nominee for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. I have known Katarina since she first joined the department as a doctoral student in the 2022-2023 academic year. She took my graduate seminar in the fall of 2023 on "Minoritarian Aesthetics" and audited a graduate seminar I taught in the fall of 2024 on "New Directions in Asian American Literature and Asian Americanist Critique." I am currently a member of dissertation committee, and am the faculty sponsor for the Asian American Reading Group that she coordinates with fellow graduate students. I have also been her mentor for the GRM and GSRM. I have come to know Katarina very well, both as a scholar and a teacher, and can say with confidence that she is one of the most thoughtful instructors I've come across in my time mentoring graduate students on their work and pedagogy.

I have continued to be impressed and excited by Katarina's excellent scholarship, which offers critical engagements with contemporary Asian American art, literature, poetry, and games working across the fields of disability studies, Asian American studies, game studies, environmental humanities, and indigenous studies. Moreover, I have enjoyed getting to know more about Katarina's teaching—both her syllabi that she designs, but also her pedagogical style in the classroom.

Katarina has regularly shared with me syllabi she's designed for ENGL 4W, a Creative Reading and Writing course required for students across an array of majors, not just English. We talk about the materials she assigns, and I'll do the same, sometimes leading us to exchanging different cultural objects—in this way she already models a generous collegiality that is nonterritorial and instead, open. I have been struck by how her syllabi are fun and playful, yet quite meticulous in their approach to a particular topic. For instance, in one ENGL 4W syllabus she designed on "Human Consumption," she asked her students: What do we, as humans, consume, but also what consumes us in turn? How do we understand ourselves as consumers when taking into account race, gender, class, and culture? Course readings included the work of poets Sylvia Plath and Ocean Vuong, the speculative fiction of H.G. Wells, and the Stephen Sondehim musical, *Sweeney Todd*. Students wrote short papers, which, by the end of the quarter, constituted a portfolio that catalogued their thinking throughout and the course. Students were then able to look at the trajectory of their thinking and reflect on how their papers came together.

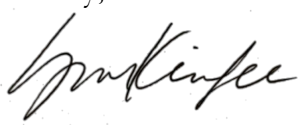
Getting to see her actually teach in the classroom really solidified my high regard for her teaching. This past fall quarter of 2025, Katarina invited me and another colleague to sit in on her ENGL 4W course, "Asian/American Speculation," which considered genre fiction's role in constructing and transforming our perceptions of Asian/Americanness by looking to a range of work in horror, speculative fiction, and fantasy.

The syllabus included contemporary poetry by Franny Choi, the film *Everything Everywhere All at Once*, and the writing of Edward Said—adding up to another rich, diverse, interdisciplinary syllabus. The day I visited the class, Katarina had her students learn about role-playing games (RPGs)—specifically Dungeons and Dragons (DnD)—which one of her dissertation chapters addresses through an analysis of the racialization of its characters/players over time, from its emergence in the 1970s to the present. I hardly know much about the game, and a majority of the students did not either.

Katarina knew this and had planned accordingly. In class, she gave us the history of DnD as a game, and then patiently, with infectious enthusiasm, explained step-by-step how the game works, bringing us in as players creating our own characters and rolling the dice to see how our decisions in the game advance the narrative. Katarina then had students collectively close read one of the early DnD rulebooks, asking them to take note of the language used to describe certain creatures in the game, like orcs, described as "savage" and "primitive." She had them think about how racial difference is transposed onto these creatures, how racial difference is constructed through these very creatures, and how that might affect the world of the game, but also the world beyond it. At the end of class, she had students practice writing out a thesis statement based on class discussion—reminding them that a thesis statement should propose or assert an idea that someone else can disagree with, which then requires evidence and an argument. Students wrote thesis statements that were then shared with the rest of the class for discussion, feedback, and finetuning. That not only the rules of a RPG, but also close reading and thesis statements were covered in one class was a feat, all while feeling active and fun.

I have no doubt that Katarina's skills as a teacher will only strengthen over time, and set her up well in her academic career. Often, for some academics, teaching takes a backseat to research. Katarina is that rare scholar in that for her, both are a priority. She doesn't see teaching as a hindrance to her research, nor does she her research as distinct from what she brings to the classroom. Her for, their dynamic relation to each other is what makes the classroom a space for critical inquiry, close reading, and rigorous analysis. She has my highest recommendation. Please do not hesitate to reach out should you have any further questions for me.

Sincerely,



Summer Kim Lee
Assistant Professor of English, UCLA